herself while finishing her degree. She was soon embroiled in a major struggle to maintain her job after articles appeared in California newspapers publicizing that she was a communist.[35] Davis had not hidden this fact, but due to an old statute of the McCarran Act carried over from the McCarthy era, university regents were permitted to fire instructors based on affiliation with the Communist Party. California governor Ronald Reagan and the regents sought to have her removed in 1969. Davis's detractors merged anticommunist sentiment with fears of black intellectual empowerment.

During this time, Davis also joined the Soledad Brothers Defense Committee, working to free a trio of imprisoned men in the Soledad Prison. George Jackson, John Clutchette, and Fleeta Drumgo, who were known for their liberation teachings from inside Soledad, had been indicted suspiciously for murdering a prison guard. In 1970 Jackson published *Soledad Brother*, his own counternarrative of his imprisonment.[36] Davis's defense of her faculty job and her involvement with the Soledad case helped exemplify and reveal challenges to her own philosophies and practices of freedom that rebuffed what she saw as the far-reaching manifestations of the U.S. prison and repressive political systems. In August 1970, Davis was charged with aiding an armed attack on a Marin County courtroom by Jonathan Jackson, George Jackson's younger brother. When it was found Jackson used firearms Davis owned, but without her knowledge, her life as an intellectual was rendered inseparable from her flight from capture and the justice system. As a prisoner awaiting trial, she formed networks of solidarity with other political prisoners and became a leading dissenting voice of the criminal justice system.[37]

In turn, prisons emerged as central sites of Davis's meaningful organizing work and critical studies. Her attention to boundaries of freedom and repression would undergird her writing before the publication of her autobiography. While the symbol of walls would more fully emerge in her book, close readings of Davis's work from the period before and during her imprisonment in 1970–72 reveal a genealogy of walls, preceding her public mention of Berlin's wall (though not by name) in her autobiography as part of her expressive repertoire. Works written by and in support of her freedom bear the imprint of the evolving symbol and lexicon of walls.

Davis joined a literary tradition of incarcerated authors and criminal justice critics who employ the symbol of walls to write from and/or about prisons. Caleb Smith argues that canonical American authors imagine space